

the ARVN spent too much time complaining, but the conditions under which many served were deplorable. The official number of ARVN desertions was unusually high, although statistics were misleading because a soldier absent for even one day was listed as being a deserter, rather than absent without leave (AWOL). Many soldiers only missed reporting for duty on one or two days or joined another unit closer to their home while still listed as a deserter on another roster.

ARVN conscription methods were severe, and the Saigon government was largely unresponsive to the personal needs of its troops. ARVN soldiers received no mail, their pay was meager, and barracks and dependent housing were in short supply and corruptly allocated. Food rations were inadequate and frequently pilfered. American canned goods and soy sauce were poor substitutes for the fish, rice, vegetables, and nuoc mam cham (fish sauce) that were the staples of the South Vietnamese diet.

“I always returned to the fighting, but **close to home ...** that is how Vietnamese had fought for centuries.”

INTERVIEW WITH PHAN THUY, ARVN ARTILLERY OFFICER, 1999



Manning a gun emplacement

Soldiers of the ARVN man a gun emplacement in June 1970. These largely conscripted troops were often very young and poorly trained. The arms and equipment were overwhelmingly supplied by the US.

Motivation to fight